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A CRISIS OF IDENTITY

After May 4, the Congress faces a deep crisis: shrinking footprint, growing Muslim-South identity, delayed decisions and Rahul Gandhi's failure to convert narratives into votes

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By the time results from five state elections began pouring in on May 4, the Congress had been left smaller, more southern and more Muslim in its political profile than at any point in its history. The verdicts sharpened a fear long haunting the Congress: that its national footprint is steadily narrowing even as the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) argues that the Grand Old Party no longer speaks for a broad cross-section of India.

In Assam, the Congress was reduced to 19 MLAs, its worst-ever tally, while its projected 'face', Gaurav Gogoi, lost from Jorhat. In West Bengal, where it had drawn a blank in 2021, it returned with just two seats. In Tamil Nadu, the party fell from 18 MLAs to five. Its rapid post-poll shift from the old ally Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) to Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK)—sealed by party leader Rahul Gandhi's presence at the swearing-in—looked less like strategic agility than an admission that the original alliance call had failed. In Puducherry, too, the Congress-DMK alliance could not prevent the National Democratic Alliance's second successive victory.